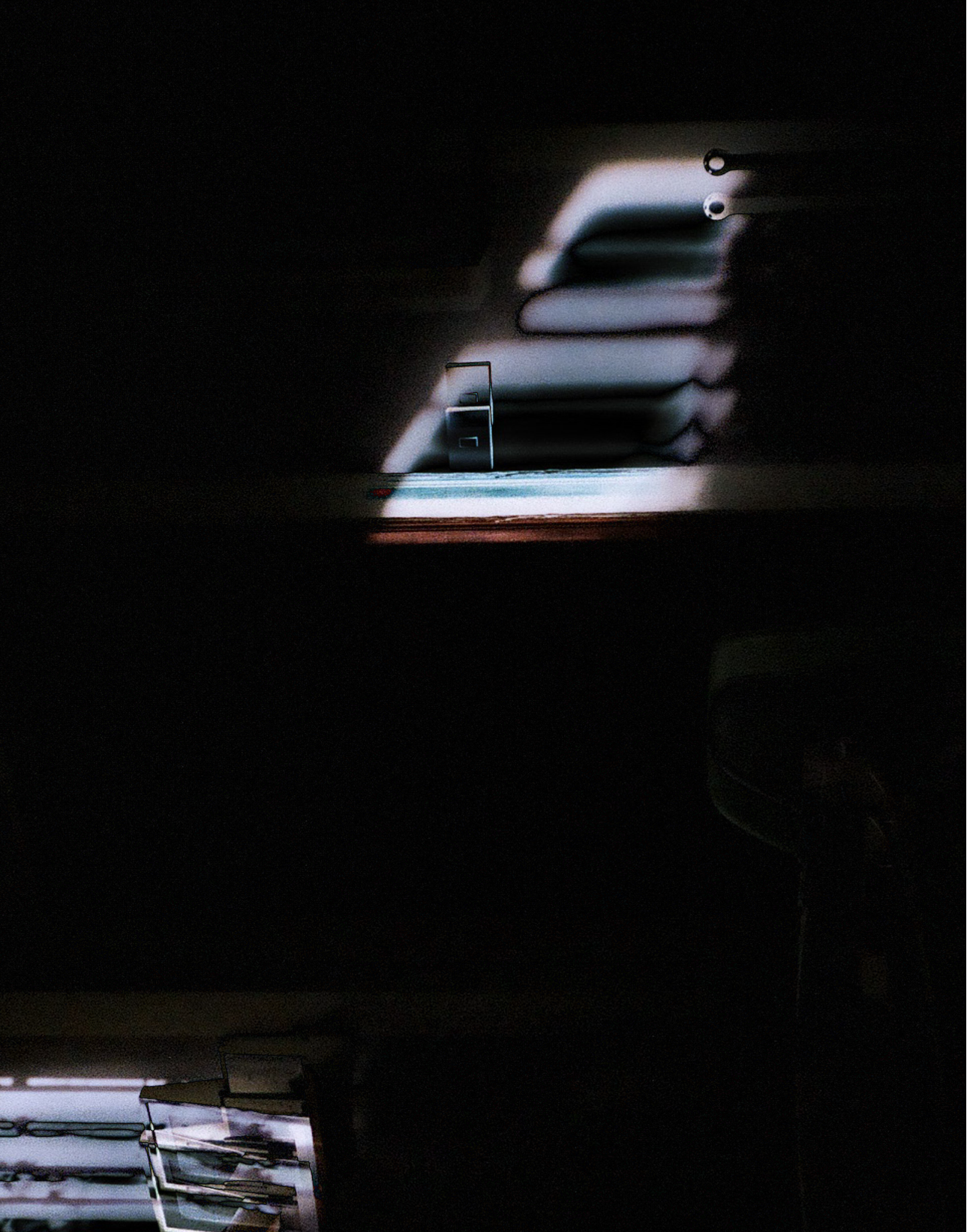

RENDEZ-VOUS WITH FILEP MOTWARY

Born in 1977 in Cyprus, Filep Motwary was initially trained as a fashion designer before he became an independent fashion curator and critic, film director and photographer.
He is the author of two books and since 2004, he has interviewed an approximate list of 500 esteemed personalities from the world of fashion and the arts, among others are Shirin Neshat, Donatella Versace, Thomas Houseago, Rick Owens, Hussein Chalayan, Valerie Steele...
In 2016 he curated the acclaimed exhibition “Haute-à-Porter” that was presented at the Modemuseum Hasselt which was voted as one of the TOP 3 for that year by Forbes magazine. Another success was the “SYNERGY: Art into Fashion” exhibition that was presented at the A. G. Leventis Gallery in Nicosia [April to September 2022]; He is considered an expert on upcoming designers in Europe and he is often invited to mentor young creatives.
He has participated in various competitions as a jury member while art-directing and creating costumes for acclaimed plays, music videos, and films.
Motwary has signed a stellar list of interviews for Dapper Dan magazine where he worked for 14 years. From 2018 he holds the position of Vogue Greece’s Editor-at-Large.

AE: What experiences or influences have shaped your unique artistic voice as a curator, photographer and critic?
FM: I approach things through a fantasy perspective: the critical zone made of independence. At a younger age, trial and error was a good way of evolving. After many years of work one has enough experience to own your craft and play with it. Our brain is like a hard drive that collects information that resonates with our tastes or not. My obsession with American cinema, observing my seamstress mother working directly on her clients bodies to create impeccable dresses, the fact that I still find time to daydream, the different acquaintances I came across throughout the years, knowledge that comes with intensional reading, attending, observing and committing myself entirely to my metier by my own terms. Yet, I must say that I have no other inspiration than the body itself.

AE: How has your work at Vogue Greece allowed you to express your creative vision and contribute to the fashion landscape?

FM: I have been contributing to the fashion landscape for many years before Vogue offered me the position of editor-at-large, 5 years ago. My stories for Vogue are thematically consistent and in coherence with the publication. There are certain parameters. Thankfully, my position allows enough freedom while my stories are usually illustrated by my photography. In a sense, I am offering a full package as the result is truly about an exclusive and personal look into the world of high fashion through my own eyes. Long before Vogue (2004), I used to have a blog that won plenty of awards due to the originality of its content and it was mostly about interviewing people that interested

me, documenting my everyday life in the big fashion capitals, etc. The page was created out of pure love for fashion and my never-ending curiosity and in parallel to my life as a designer. This was an experience that opened my perspective and freed me. The blog opened new horizons for me like curating fashion in museums, writing for magazines, photographing, and all the rest of the things my name is known for. The blog was shut down in 2014 with the rise of Instagram. It was impossible to compete.

AE: Absurdism often challenges conventional norms. How do you navigate the challenges of incorporating absurd elements into fashion without alienating the audience or losing the essence of wearability?

FM: Absurdity does exist and it's valuable because it makes people think and be more creative or even more interesting. There are numerous designers whose work confirms the necessity of suggesting something different. Take for example Comme Des Garcons, Harri, Thom Browne and previously McQueen, Galliano etc.
However, all these great designers show different things on their runway shows than what they sell at their showrooms. These absurd clothes make headlines and maintain a designer's reputation through fashion exhibitions, fashion editorials, celebrities while they are sold for very high prices to private collectors and institutions. It's a win-win situation.

AE: To you, are absurd outfits presented on fashion shows an act of crossing conventional norms or just playing childish or something third?

FM: It really depends on the message the designer wants to put out and how well it is communicated with the audience. A fashion show serves as the bridge between the brand and its guests (journalists, celebrities, fans) and less with the buyers of the collection. It's about the image and usually a very strong communication trick that will elongate the memory of the show, either be it a celebrity model, a live orchestra, a special performance, the location etc.

AE: What challenges have you faced in your career, and how have they contributed to your growth as a creative professional?

FM: I had to restart my life from scratch twice, which enabled me to test my limits. It helped me understand who I really am. I don't understand challenges, I don't see life as something challenging or something to worry too much about.

AE: Are there personal experiences or values that you bring into your professional work, and if so, how do they manifest?

FM: I try to be honest and change only the things I can. The more I grow the more I accept that the world is not perfect yet it doesn't stop me from trying for the best. Everyone becomes different with the practice of their skills.

AE: What are your aspirations for the future, both personally and professionally, within the realm of fashion and creative expression?

FM: My hope is to meet interesting people and work together on ideas that will maintain and encourage aesthetic harmony and continuous stimulation for knowledge. I am less and less interested in proving myself to anyone other than me.

IMPOSSIBLE RENDEZ - VOUS NO. 3

Coco Chanel & Benjamin Netanyahu

In a fantastical setting where time and space were mere suggestions, Coco Chanel and Benjamin Netanyahu found themselves seated in an opulent Parisian salon adorned with elegant black and white designs and the faint scent of Chanel No. 5 lingering in the air.

Drawing by Mobina Khalili